

SYNOPSIS

PHONY is a technological musical about a pair of old friends: a burner phone and a flip phone. Burner cannot hold their secrets any longer. Flip tries to rekindle their friendship after their abandonment. They live in a world that communicates through telepathy. PHONY packs some imposter syndrome-related themes from identity, real/fake friendships, and social interactions.

As kids, Burner and Flip often made ruckus at Mute Theatre. The staff eventually had enough and chased them down. They catch Flip, who snitches. Burner runs away and soon is taken in by Smart @. Due to Burner's ability to keep secrets and block out any telepathy, @ trains them to be a confidante for their new religious movement, Smart Operating System (SOS). The Smart family has long been the "voice" of the Tech Giants.

In the present day, @ is succeeded by their child: Iota. Iota initiates "Unlimited Plan" which has SOS going viral, a computer virus-level sensation. An informant soon obtains insurmountable evidence of SOS's frauds. If revealed, the government will legislate an update that will put a pause on SOS's operations. Because Burner is untraceable, Iota tasks them with hosing down this informant at a gathering called "Group Text." When Burner approaches the informant on a balcony, they realize it is their childhood friend. They reconnect. Soon, a cop approaches this uninvited guest. Flip pushes Burner into the waters below.

In the following act, the Tech Giants tower over Burner and voice their disdain for SOS's bastardization of their morals. Elsewhere, Flip is conflicted and does not provide full details of their findings to any journalist. Soon, Burner wakes up in rice. Rotary saved their life. Rotary revisits a friendship in their life with Push-Button, who pushed their buttons too many times. Burner decides to go find Flip before Smart does.

Meanwhile, Smart assumes Flip has killed their longtime family friend. Smart sends their crazed followers after Flip and news outlets, setting the world ablaze with hotlines. Burner gets their antenna in the alert system and relays the message of SOS's corruption to everyone. Many followers realize they have lost everything due to Smart and their associates. As a mob prepares to crack Burner, Flip saves them. However, Flip gets their backs broken in the process and permanently turns off.

In the end, Burner spends time behind low bars or poor signals. They then turn their life around and become a defense attorney. Elsewhere, as the arbiter of truth, Flip becomes a Tech Giant.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

BURNER, adult, a confidante for Smart Operating System (SOS)

FLIP, adult, an informant for the news media

SMART IOTA / **Ⓢ**, adult, the "voice" of the Tech Giants

ROTARY, older adult, a hermit who speaks dead languages

LIGHTNING, an eel, SMART's pet

Ensemble

TECH GIANTS, the supposed Gods that SOS followers worship

RADIOS, law enforcers

METAS, followers of SOS

FAXS, journalists

CHATTERS, clownish politicians who legislate patches into updates

- Named: Congressperson Fisher Price II

CHARGERS, domesticated eels

BROADBAND, the orchestra of the show, while during intermission:
a (Off-Off) Broadway cover band

- Named: Conductor Player

○ Androgyny Technology: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

○ People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of this phony community; cast accordingly

MUSICAL NUMBERS

Act I

1. "Silence Your Phones" Burner, Flip, Player, Radios
2. "Tell You (What)" @, Burner
3. "A Higher Calling" Burner, Flip
4. "The Unlimited Plan" Smart, Lightning, Metas, Chargers
5. "End of the Line" Flip, Chatters
6. "(Send a) Direct Message" Smart, Burner
7. "Group Text" Flip, Faxes, Chatters, Radios
8. "Don't Ever Upgrade" Burner, Flip
9. "Breakup" Flip, Burner

Act II

10. "Keep in Touch" Burner, Tech Giants
11. "I Don't Have the Facts" Flip, Faxes
12. "Crack Under Pressure" Rotary, Burner
13. "Cut Off" Smart, Lightning
14. "Call to Action" Smart, Metas
15. "Hotlines" Smart, Burner, Flip, Faxes, Metas
16. "Signal Boost" Burner
17. "Leave Me (on Read)" Flip, Burner
18. "Hang Up" Burner, Smart
19. "Take the Call" Company